

ORIGINAL RESEARCH

The Indian AI Search Audit

500 queries. 25 brands. 777 citations. The first published audit of how AI search platforms cite Indian brands across ChatGPT, Google AI Overview, Gemini, Claude, and Perplexity.

By Ravi Patel · Founder, Citare

citare.ai/reports · methodology + per-brand data inside

TL;DR — FIVE FINDINGS

AI engines cite Instagram before they cite *any brand's website*.

We ran 500 AI search queries against 25 Indian brands across 72 hours. The most-cited domains weren't brand websites at all. The first brand-owned site appeared at position 12 in our top-cited list.

#	FINDING	THE NUMBER
1	The most-cited domains aren't brand websites. Instagram, jimmyluxury.in (one indie blog), YouTube, Reddit, and aggregators dominate.	Instagram: 21 citations First brand site: position 12
2	The branded vs unbranded gap is huge. Brand-name comparisons surface; unbranded category queries don't.	73.3% branded 33.5% unbranded 40pt gap
3	AIO and ChatGPT are different products. Per-brand surface rates diverge by up to 80 points.	Snitch: 10% AIO 90% ChatGPT 80pt gap
4	Series-A/B startups match older funded brands. AI search has no historical-authority moat.	Newer-funded: 49% Funded: 46% Wipeout: 27%
5	A single indie blog dominates an entire category. jimmyluxury.in out-cites every D2C menswear brand combined.	jimmyluxury.in: 14 citations (more than any brand)

01 How the audit was conducted

SAMPLE

25 prospects across 16 verticals — weighted toward Indian consumer brands (D2C beauty, D2C apparel, healthcare, fintech, real estate, hospitality, insurtech, jewellery) and Indian-headquartered SaaS (logistics, payroll, CRM, certification, coaching). Brands range from local SMBs to unicorns to Series B startups.

COHORTS

Three cohorts: Wipeout (10 older / mostly local brands), Funded-not-leader (10 Series B+ challengers), Newer-funded (5 Series A/B startups). Mean surface rates: 27%, 46%, 49% respectively.

QUERIES

10 queries per prospect, each grounded in the brand's stated ICPs (typically 2-3 ICPs × 3-4 queries each). Query types span unbranded category, brand-named comparisons, and intent-specific deep cuts.
500 cells total (10 queries × 2 platforms × 25 brands).

PLATFORMS

2 platforms — Google AI Overview (AIO) and ChatGPT (web interface). AIO captured via screenshot + cited-URL parsing. ChatGPT captured for body text (brand mention + position) and structured response. **777 citation URLs** extracted from AIO cells.

CRITICAL NOTE: REAL BROWSER, NOT API

All queries ran through **real browser sessions**, not LLM APIs. This matters because API responses differ materially from what users actually see on the public AI search interfaces — different retrieval, different ranking, different citation behavior. Most other AI search visibility tools use API. **The numbers above only hold for browser-based measurement.**

FINDING 1

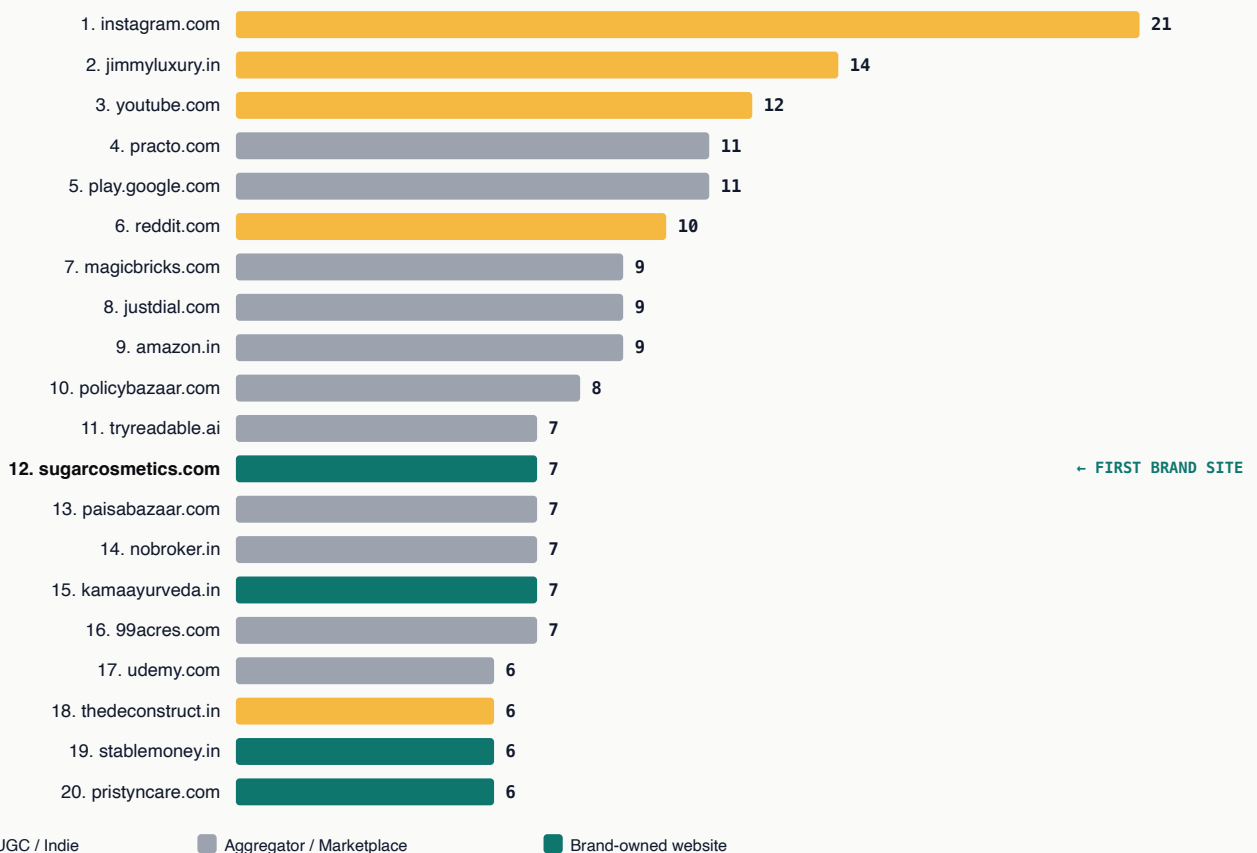
The most-cited domains for Indian buyer queries *are not brand websites.*

12

POSITION OF FIRST BRAND-OWNED WEBSITE IN TOP-CITED LIST

Instagram tops the list. Brand websites barely register.

Across 500 cells, AI engines cited Instagram (21), one indie blog (14), YouTube (12), Practo (11), Google Play (11), and Reddit (10) before any brand-owned website. The first brand site to appear was sugarcosmetics.com at position 12 with 7 citations.



Indian brand marketing teams are spending the vast majority of their content budget on owned-property SEO — blog posts, landing pages, product pages — designed to rank in Google blue links. AI engines reading Indian buyer queries are not preferentially weighting any of that.

The earned and rented surfaces — Instagram posts, indie blogger listicles, app store reviews, aggregator listings — are. The gap is real and it holds across every vertical we measured. **The owned-property SEO investment isn't converting to AI search citation share.**

FINDING 2

There's a *40-point gap* between branded and unbranded query surface rates.

40

PERCENTAGE-POINT GAP BETWEEN BRANDED AND UNBRANDED QUERY SURFACE

Brand search is won by default. Unbranded is the battle.

Branded comparison queries ('X vs Y') surface brands 73.3% of the time (66/90 cells). Unbranded 'best X' queries surface them only 33.5% (106/316 cells). The 40-point gap is where the actual AI-search opportunity lives.



If a user is already searching 'Acko vs HDFC ERGO,' Acko surfaces because the query forced the mention. The brand-marketing investment that built that comparison-awareness is paying out, but the AI search layer is just a passthrough.

The actual battle is in the unbranded category surface — the 316 cells where a user types 'best health insurance for parents with diabetes' or 'best Bangalore D2C menswear under ₹2000' with no brand in mind. In those queries, only one in three brands we audited surfaces at all. **And the brands that do surface are mostly the ones with strong third-party citation graphs — not the ones with strong on-site SEO.**

FINDING 3

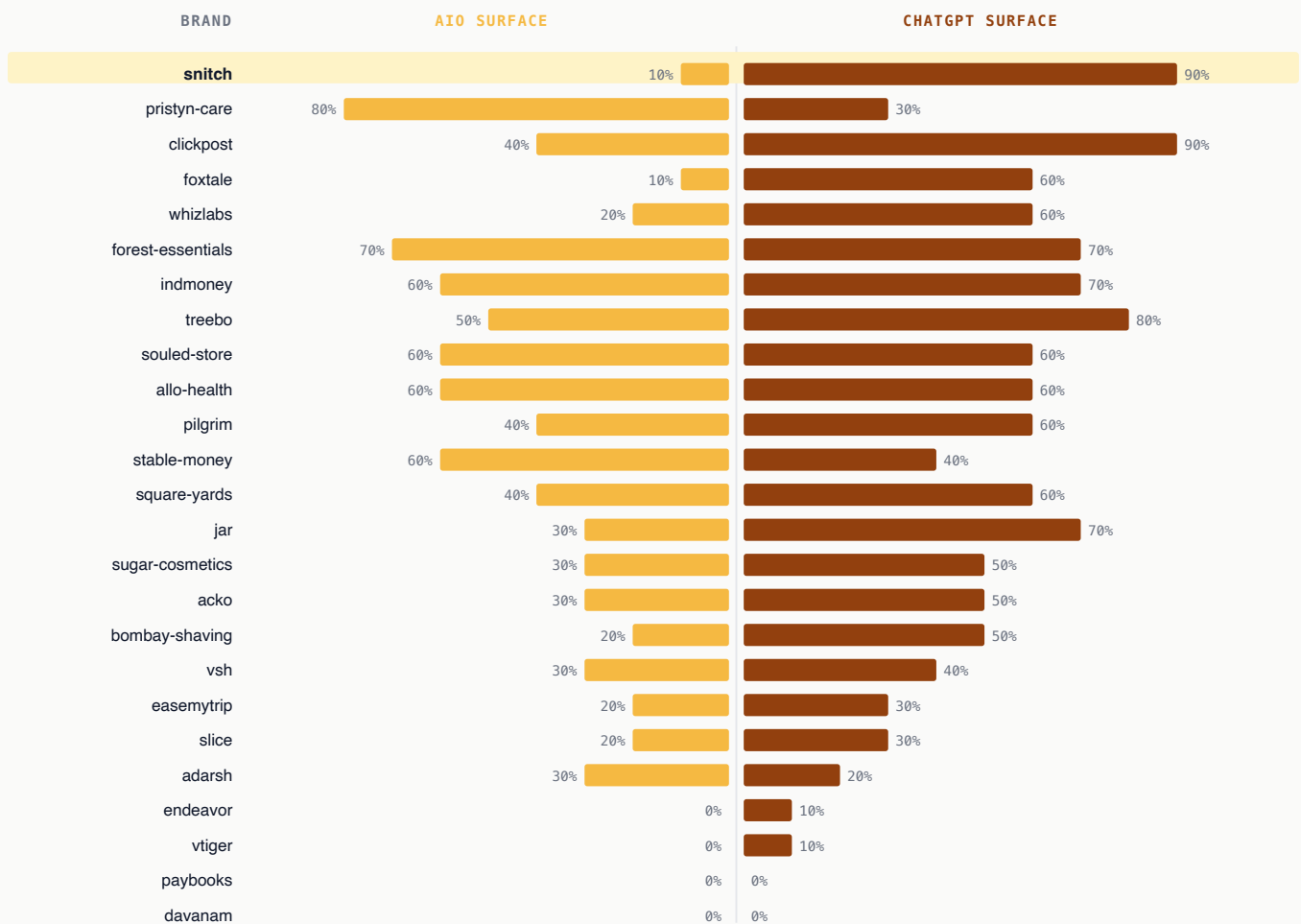
Per-brand AIO vs ChatGPT asymmetry runs as high as 80 percentage points.

LARGEST PER-BRAND GAP BETWEEN GOOGLE AI OVERVIEW AND CHATGPT SURFACE RATE

80

Snitch surfaces 10% on AIO. 90% on ChatGPT. Same brand, same queries.

Per-brand surface rates diverge dramatically between platforms. Snitch (Series B menswear): 10% AIO, 90% ChatGPT. Pristyn Care (healthcare unicorn): 80% AIO, 30% ChatGPT. Clickpost (logistics SaaS): 40% AIO, 90% ChatGPT.



The pattern is not directional. Some brands win bigger on AIO; others win bigger on ChatGPT; the same vertical (healthcare) has Pristyn AIO-favored and other audited brands invisible to both. **There is no single AI search optimization strategy.**

AIO's citation graph favors aggregator sites and brand websites with strong technical SEO. ChatGPT's training and retrieval favors long-form earned content and brand mentions in third-party sources. A brand with strong aggregator listings wins AIO. A brand with strong long-form earned content wins ChatGPT. **You have to measure your brand on each platform separately.**

FINDING 4

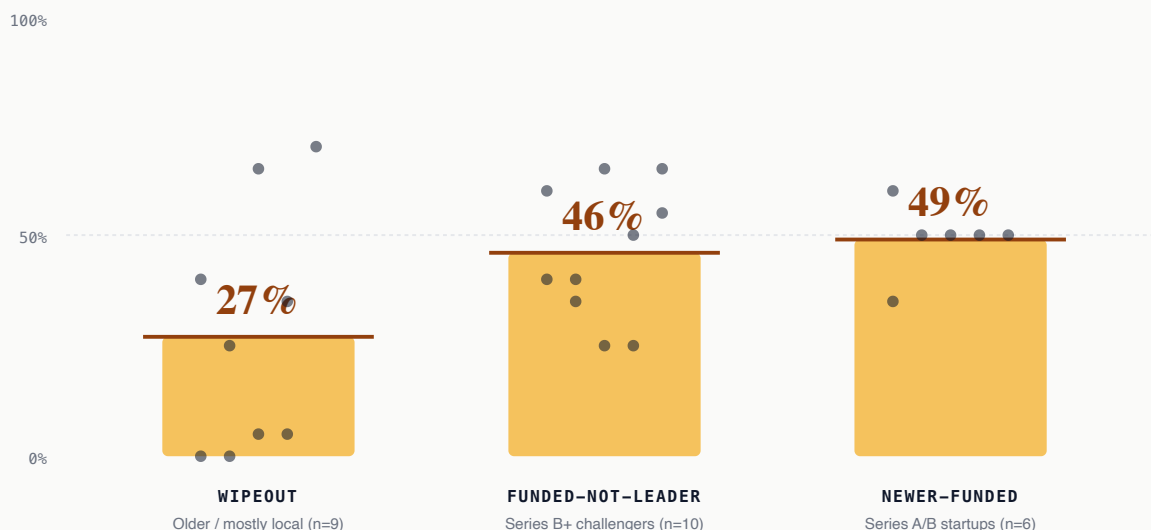
Series-A/B startups *match older funded brands* on AI search.

49%

AVERAGE SURFACE RATE FOR NEWER-FUNDED COHORT (BEATS FUNDED-NOT-LEADER AVG 46%)

AI search has no historical-authority moat.

Cohort averages: Wipeout (older / mostly local): 27%. Funded-not-leader (Series B+ challengers): 46%. Newer-funded (Series A/B startups): 49%. The 3-point gap between Series A/B and Series B+ is within margin of error.



A 22-year-old open-source CRM with 400,000 customers (Vtiger) surfaces in 1 of 20 cells. A 4-year-old D2C startup (Snitch) surfaces in 10 of 20 cells. The gap is funding-correlated, not age-correlated.

The implication for newer Indian brands: a Series A startup investing intentionally in the surfaces AI engines actually read (social, Reddit, listicle blogs, aggregators) can match or exceed the AI search visibility of a unicorn that's been building classical SEO for a decade. **Good news if you're building. Warning if you're an incumbent assuming classical SEO equity transfers to AI.**

FINDING 5

A single indie listicle blog *dominates an entire category's* AI citations.

CITATIONS JIMMYLUXURY.IN RECEIVED ACROSS THE AUDIT (MORE THAN ANY BRAND WEBSITE)

14

One blog out-cites every D2C menswear brand combined.

jimmyluxury.in is an indie SEO listicle blog with titles like 'Top 50 Luxury Brands for Men in India' and 'Top Trending D2C Men's Fashion Brands.' It received 14 citations across the audit — more than any brand's own website in any vertical.

● BEAUTY

instagram.com

10 citations · social

● HEALTHCARE

practo.com

11 citations · agg

● REAL-ESTATE

magicbricks.com

9 citations · agg

● INSURTECH

policybazaar.com

8 citations · agg

● FINTECH

play.google.com

7 citations · market

● D2C-APPAREL

jimmyluxury.in

14 citations · indie

● JEWELLERY

justdial.com

6 citations · agg

● COACHING

imsindia.com

6 citations · brand
(competitor)

● CERT-SAAS

udemy.com

6 citations · market

● HOSPITALITY

tripadvisor.in

4 citations · agg

● OTA-TRAVEL

makemytrip.com

3 citations · brand
(competitor)

● CRM-SAAS

1channel.co

1 citations · other

AI engines reach for comprehensive listicles when answering category questions. A page titled 'Top 50 Luxury Brands for Men in India' with 50 brand names + pros/cons is, from an AI engine's perspective, **the perfect retrieval target**: authoritative-looking, brand-rich, evergreen, answer-shaped.

The strategic move: identify the 3-5 jimmyluxury.in-equivalents in your category. Get listed in them. If you're not in them, contact the blog owner and propose inclusion. If a category doesn't have a jimmyluxury equivalent, this is one of the highest-leverage SEO content gaps for a competitor to fill.

02 Methodology limitations + how to read this data

Sample is Indian-skewed. All 25 brands are Indian-headquartered or India-primary. The findings about citation graphs (Instagram dominance, aggregator dominance, listicle dominance) likely hold elsewhere directionally, but the specific domains will differ. US queries may favor different aggregators (Yelp, G2, Capterra); UK queries different again. We don't claim global findings from this sample.

AIO body text was not captured. AIO surface scoring is based on cited URLs only. If a brand is mentioned in the AIO summary text but not cited, our methodology marks it as not-surfaced. This understates AIO surface rates marginally. We are addressing this in future audits via OCR + named-entity extraction on the AIO screenshot capture.

The audit window is 72 hours. AI search retrieval shifts weekly. Numbers in this report are accurate as of 24-26 May 2026. We will republish updates quarterly to track drift. A brand's surface rate in any single audit window is a snapshot, not a trend — readers should treat per-brand numbers as directional rather than absolute.

Sample is curated for breadth, not statistical representativeness. 25 brands across 16 verticals is enough for vertical-level patterns but too small for strict statistical claims about any single vertical (most verticals have only 1-3 brands in the sample). Cross-vertical findings (top-cited domains, branded vs unbranded gap, AIO/ChatGPT asymmetry) are robust at this sample size. Single-vertical conclusions should be read as illustrative.

VERTICAL BREAKDOWN · INDIAN FINTECH

Indian fintech: *aggregators rule, app store reviews carry weight.*

INDIAN FINTECH BRANDS AUDITED IN COHORT

5

play.google.com tops the cited-domain list for fintech queries.

Acko (40% surface), Slice (25%), Jar (50%), Stable Money (50%), IndMoney (65%). Top competitor across cohort: HDFC ERGO + Groww + PhonePe + Paisabazaar (different competitor per sub-vertical).

Indian fintech AI search citations are dominated by Google Play Store review pages (7 citations), Paisabazaar (7), and brand sites of category leaders (stablemoney.in 6, plus older entrants). The pattern is consistent: AI engines treat fintech app stores as a primary trust signal — likely because Play Store reviews are the highest-volume, most structured user-generated content available in the category.

Implication for fintech brands: if your Play Store presence is thin (low review count, no responses to user complaints, outdated app description), you're losing AI search visibility before any blog content can rescue you.

Play Store optimization is the highest-leverage GEO move for Indian fintech in 2026. The brand sites that DO surface (stablemoney.in, pristyncare.com) have one thing in common: they invest heavily in long-form comparison content that's been indexed for 12+ months.

VERTICAL BREAKDOWN • INDIAN D2C BEAUTY

D2C beauty: *Instagram is the primary AI citation surface.*

INDIAN D2C BEAUTY BRANDS AUDITED IN COHORT

4

Instagram (10 citations) leads. Brand sites trail in the 5-7 range.

Sugar Cosmetics (40% surface — first brand site in our top-cited list at position 12), Forest Essentials (70% — highest surface in entire corpus), Pilgrim (50%), Foxtale (35%).

Beauty is the vertical where the Instagram-dominance finding hits hardest. Instagram leads the citation graph with 10 mentions; brand sites (sugarcosmetics.com 7, kamaayurveda.in 7, forestessentialsindia.com 5) follow but in aggregate get fewer citations than Instagram alone. YouTube reviews (4 citations) and indie blog thedeconstruct.in (6) round out the surface that AI engines reach for on beauty buyer queries.

The hero-product trap: Forest Essentials shows it cleanly. The brand has the highest surface rate in our entire corpus (70%) — but on Kumkumadi-specific queries (their flagship hero product), Forest Essentials is invisible. Kama Ayurveda owns those cells entirely. **Brand-level AI search visibility doesn't transfer to product-level AI search visibility.** Beauty brands need to audit hero-product queries separately from category queries.

VERTICAL BREAKDOWN · INDIAN HEALTHCARE

Healthcare: *Practo wins, but per-brand divergence is extreme.*

INDIAN HEALTHCARE BRANDS AUDITED IN COHORT

3

Pristyn Care surfaces 80% on AIO, 30% on ChatGPT — same brand, same queries.

Pristyn Care (55% — biggest AIO/ChatGPT asymmetry in corpus), VSH Hospital (35%), Allo Health (60%). Practo (11 citations) leads the category citation graph; Apollo + Manipal dominate ChatGPT body text.

Healthcare is the vertical where AIO and ChatGPT diverge most sharply at the brand level. Pristyn Care surfaces in 80% of AIO cells (rich citation graph via healthcare directory listings + pristyncare.com URLs) but only 30% of ChatGPT cells, where the body text defaults to legacy hospital chains. Practo dominates the per-vertical citation graph with 11 mentions across 20 cells — more than any other domain in healthcare.

The brand-rename indexing finding: VSH Hospital (rebranded from Mallya 4 years ago) shows that **ChatGPT has cleanly indexed the rename**, surfacing current contact details and routing old-Mallya searches to VSH. AIO is partially there but lags on operating-status queries (still citing legacy Mallya-name directories). For any brand that has rebranded, this matters: **different AI platforms index brand transitions at different speeds.**

03 Per-brand findings · all 25 brands audited

Each card shows surface rate (cells where the brand appeared / total cells), per-platform breakdown (AIO / ChatGPT), top competitor by mention count, and the most actionable finding for that brand. Sample audit window: 24-26 May 2026.

Forest Essentials

BEAUTY

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
70%	70%	70%	Kama Ayurveda

Highest surface rate in our corpus. But absent from product-specific Kumkumadi queries — Kama Ayurveda owns those.

Clickpost

LOGISTICS-SAAS

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
65%	40%	90%	AfterShip

50-point AIO/ChatGPT asymmetry (ChatGPT-favored). AfterShip is the top-mentioned competitor (8 mentions).

IndMoney

WEALTHTECH

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
65%	60%	70%	Groww

Holds parity in unbranded "best Indian investing app" cells. Wins outright on US stocks queries.

Treebo

HOSPITALITY

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
65%	50%	80%	FabHotels

Strongest brand performer in budget hospitality. Wins on tripadvisor.in citation chains + brand-named queries.

Souled Store

D2C-APPAREL

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
60%	60%	60%	Bewakoof

AI engines cite Souled Store via jimmyluxury.in listicles (4 times) rather than the brand site directly.

Allo Health

HEALTHCARE

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
60%	60%	60%	Bold Care

Series A startup matching established brands. Citations from Reddit, YouTube, category aggregators.

Pristyn Care

HEALTHCARE

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
55%	80%	30%	Apollo Hospitals

Largest AIO-favored asymmetry in corpus (50pt). AIO loves Pristyn; ChatGPT defaults to legacy hospital chains.

Pilgrim

BEAUTY

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
50%	40%	60%	Mamaearth

Wins "Pilgrim vs Mamaearth" cells. Loses unbranded "best Indian beauty brand" queries to Forest Essentials.

Snitch

D2C-APPAREL

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
50%	10%	90%	Souled Store

Largest platform asymmetry in entire corpus (80pt). ChatGPT cites Snitch via jimmyluxury.in; AIO ignores.

03 Per-brand findings • continued

Jar

FINTECH

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
50%	30%	70%	PhonePe

Wins brand-named comparison cells. Loses unbranded "best digital gold app India" to PhonePe + Paytm.

Stable Money

FINTECH

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
50%	60%	40%	Paisabazaar

AIO-favored; stablemoney.in domain is #19 in most-cited list. Paisabazaar dominates fintech content presence.

Square Yards

REAL-ESTATE

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
50%	40%	60%	NoBroker

Aggregator citation moat (MagicBricks, NoBroker, 99acres) dominates the category. Brand sites barely register.

Acko

INSURTECH

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
40%	30%	50%	HDFC ERGO

Strong on brand-named comparisons. Flagship Platinum Health product absent from unforced queries.

Sugar Cosmetics

BEAUTY

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
40%	30%	50%	Maybelline

sugarcosmetics.com is the FIRST brand-owned site to appear in our top-cited list (position 12).

Whizlabs

CERT-SAAS

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
40%	20%	60%	Udemy

40-point platform asymmetry (ChatGPT-favored). Udemy + Tutorials Dojo dominate practice-test queries.

Foxtale

BEAUTY

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
35%	10%	60%	Minimalist

AIO is missing Foxtale entirely from its citation graph; ChatGPT indexes the brand reasonably well.

Bombay Shaving

D2C-GROOMING

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
35%	20%	50%	Beardo

Holds brand-named comparison cells against Beardo. Loses unbranded "best men's grooming brand" queries.

03 Per-brand findings • continued

VSH Hospital

HEALTHCARE

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
35%	30%	40%	Manipal Hospitals

ChatGPT clearly indexed the Mallya→VSH rename. AIO lags. Joint-replacement ICP is a complete 0/6 blind spot.

EaseMyTrip

OTA-TRAVEL

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
25%	20%	30%	MakeMyTrip

MakeMyTrip dominates (13 mentions vs EaseMyTrip's 4). Strong on US-corridor international flight queries only.

Slice

FINTECH

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
25%	20%	30%	Jupiter

Jupiter dominates Indian neobank category (7 mentions). Slice surfaces only on brand-named comparisons.

Adarsh Developers

REAL-ESTATE

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
25%	30%	20%	Brigade

Brigade dominates Bangalore real-estate (10 mentions). Adarsh holds on named-builder queries only.

Endeavor Careers

COACHING

Surface	5%	AIO	0%	ChatGPT	10%	Top:	IMS
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1 of 20 cells surfaced — from a Google Maps listing, not editorial content. IMS owns 16/20 cells.

Vtiger

CRM-SAAS

Surface	5%	AIO	0%	ChatGPT	10%	Top:	Zoho
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22 years, 400K customers, original SugarCRM fork — and surfaces in 1/20 cells. Outranked by Twenty + EspoCRM.

Davanam Jewellers

JEWELLERY

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
0%	0%	0%	Tanishq

0 of 20 cells. Even queries tailored to brand's strongest territory (South Bangalore) returned zero mentions.

Paybooks

PAYROLL-SAAS

Surface	AIO	ChatGPT	Top:
0%	0%	0%	greytHR

0 of 20 cells. greytHR dominates Indian payroll-SaaS (14 mentions across 20 cells, every ICP cluster).

02 Five practical actions for brand teams

1 Audit your Instagram presence specifically for buyer-intent search behavior

Instagram is the most-cited domain in our corpus. AI engines pull from Instagram Reels and posts for category recommendations. If your Instagram is brand-aesthetic-heavy and content-poor on buyer-intent topics, you're invisible to the channel AI engines weight most. **Post buyer-intent content. Tag products. Use category hashtags AI engines crawl.**

2 Get into the comprehensive listicle blogs in your category

Search 'best [your category] India' on Google. The blogs ranking top 5-10 are the ones AI engines cite when answering category questions. If you're not in those listicles, contact the bloggers and propose inclusion. **This costs less than one month of paid Google search ads and the citation lifts compound for years.**

3 Be present on the aggregators that dominate your vertical

Practo for healthcare, MagicBricks / 99acres / NoBroker for real estate, Policybazaar / Paisabazaar for insurance and finance, JustDial for local-business categories, Amazon and Play Store for product categories. AI engines treat aggregator domains as authoritative third-party sources. **Most brands underinvest in aggregator presence — incomplete listings, no reviews, outdated info.**

4 Build YouTube and Reddit presence (or seed it)

YouTube ranks #3 most-cited; Reddit ranks #6. AI engines reach for review videos and Reddit discussion threads when answering questions where buyers want third-party perspective. If your category has no YouTube comparison content, seed it. If your brand isn't being discussed on Reddit, **become a substantive participant in the relevant subreddits — long game, compounds.**

5 Measure per-platform, not globally

AIO and ChatGPT are different products. Optimizing for one doesn't transfer. Build a monthly tracking habit: query your category and your brand on each major AI platform (ChatGPT, AIO, Gemini, Claude, Perplexity). Where you don't surface, identify the cited sources that did. **Citare runs this measurement at scale across 5 platforms — see CTA.**

03 About this report + next steps

About this report. This is the first edition of an ongoing Indian AI Search Audit, published quarterly. Citare runs 10-20 single-brand audits per day for client outreach using the same methodology described here. To our knowledge, this is the first independent published research on Indian brand visibility across all five major AI search platforms. **Next edition:** August 2026.

GET YOUR BRAND AUDITED

Want to see your brand's *per-platform AI search visibility*?

Citare runs single-brand audits using the same browser-test methodology as this report. Get per-query surface rates, per-platform citation graphs, competitor benchmarks, and weekly visibility tracking across all five major AI search platforms.

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Citare · AI search visibility, measured across five platforms with real browser sessions

[citare.ai/reports](#) · methodology + per-brand data inside